



This 19th-century painting shows the Fall of Granada in 1492, which ended 780 years of Muslim rule in Spain.

None is known to have practiced it with the vigor of the **Aztecs**, however—or on the same gargantuan scale. It is estimated that the Aztecs ritually sacrificed upward of **20,000 victims a year**—slaves, enemies captured in battle, and people simply offered in tribute. The aim was to placate their gods, above all the god of war, **Huitzilopochtli**, whose daily battles with the sun could be sustained only by blood. In 1487, on the opening of the **new great temple** in the Aztec capital, **Tenochtitlán**, up to 20,000 people were ritually executed, their hearts sliced from their bodies, in a single ceremony that may have lasted anything from 4 to 20 days.

In China, the **Ming dynasty** (1368–1644) continued the

ambitious rebuilding of the 4,000-mile (6,400-km) long **Great Wall**. First built in 200 BCE, the wall had presented a symbol of superiority as well as a barrier to incursions from barbarians in the north. Under the Ming, its mountainous eastern length was built mostly of brick and stone, its western, desertlike length of clay and earth, often reinforced with wood. It stood on average 25 ft (8 m) high and 18 ft (5.5 m) wide and was studded with 25,000 towers and upward of 15,000 garrisons—a monumental feat of construction.

Tenochtitlán

This mural of the 16th-century Aztec capital imagined by 20th-century Mexican artist Diego Rivera shows the city's massive scale.



Mamluk helmet

This 15th-century iron Mamluk helmet, as worn by Mamluk soldiers, is decorated with inlaid silver calligraphy.

THE OTTOMAN–MAMLUK peace treaty of May 1491 ended a war that had begun in 1485 for control of the Western Asia and Red Sea trade routes. Neither side gained much but the war exhausted the Mamluks financially, making their subsequent conquest by the Ottomans in 1516–17 inevitable.

By 1490, **Vladislas II** (1456–1516) ruled over a vast kingdom, including **Poland–Lithuania, Bohemia, and Hungary**, whose crown he accepted in 1490. Despite the size of these territories, they had little influence on Europe as a whole. Poland–Lithuania—vast, desolate, and impoverished—was on the margins of Europe. Hungary and Bohemia, although more sophisticated, remained not just separate kingdoms but uneasy rivals. The potential of these sprawling lands would never be realized.

On January 2, 1492, Spanish monarchs **Ferdinand and Isabella** (see 1469) presided over the **fall of the Kingdom of Granada**, marking the end of a 10-year campaign to claim the last Moorish territory in Iberia. It was the end of a process begun in the 8th century—the **Christian reconquest** or **reconquista**. It underlined Spain's determination to project itself as an aggressively expansionist Christian power.

In 1492, the Spanish crown finally decided to back **Christopher Columbus's** first Atlantic crossing. Columbus had made a series of extravagant claims about the reward his voyage to the Indies (Asia) would generate. Spain was anxious to match the spoils flowing to Portugal from its West African ventures. It also needed to replace the lost revenues from

“ SAILED THIS DAY NINETEEN LEAGUES... (COUNTED) LESS THAN THE TRUE NUMBER, THAT THE CREW MIGHT NOT BE DISMAYED IF THE VOYAGE SHOULD PROVE LONG. ”

Christopher Columbus, 1492

“crusading” taxes, previously paid before the fall of Granada. Success depended on Columbus's undoubted navigational ability and on his insistence that Asia lay much farther to the east than conventionally believed. On his arrival in the **New World** on October 12, somewhere in the **Bahamas**, he immediately despatched emissaries to the “Chinese” court. Columbus's self-belief blinded him to the reality of what he had discovered.



CHRISTOPHER COLUMBUS
(c. 1451–1506)

Born in Genoa, Italy, Christopher Columbus made four transatlantic voyages believing that the riches of the East could be reached by sailing west from Spain. His first journey (1492–93) was followed by others in 1493–96, 1498–1500, and 1502–04. He was the first European to sight South America, in 1498, and charted most of the Caribbean. He died still certain he had reached Asia.

1487 Pêro da Covilhã sails through Red Sea on voyage to India (to 1489)

1487 Great pyramid inaugurated at Tenochtitlán

1489 Approximate date of Songhay raids into Mossi territory

1488 First major uprising of Ikko Buddhists in Japan

1489 Venetians purchase Cyprus, ending Frankish rule

September 18, 1490 Vladislas II, king of Hungary, becomes king of Bohemia

1491 Ottoman–Mamluk accord signed after six years of war

1492 Jews expelled from Spain by royal decree

August 3, 1492 Columbus, in search of Asia, departs Canaries and crosses Atlantic to New World

October 12, 1492 Columbus arrives in Bahamas at what he names “San Salvador”

September 25, 1493 Columbus sets sail on second voyage

1490 Mausoleum of Timur, is erected in Samarkand

1491 Brittany incorporated within France

1492 Last independent Muslim territory in Spain eliminated in conquest of Granada by Ferdinand and Isabella

August 18, 1492 Rodrigo Borgia crowned Pope Alexander VI

January 19, 1493 Charles VIII in the Eastern Pyrenees returns Cerdagne and Roussillon to Spain with the Treaty of Barcelona

1493 Muhammad Ture begins Islamification of African empire of Songhay